# Interest System Communities

Dino P. Christenson* Nathan Englehart†

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Interest system communities are networks of organized interests—such as trade associations, labor unions, professional societies, corporations, and public interest organizations—that regularly interact with one another and with government officials in a shared policy space. Community members coordinate strategy, exchange information, forge alliances, and even share staff. The structure of these ties conditions which interests secure access to policymakers and, in turn, whose voice is heard. This entry reviews the literatures that inform the concept, considers its implications for democratic representation, and concludes with questions for future research.

## I From Subgovernments to Networks

Early explanations of how organized interests influenced government policy centered on the subgovernment, sometimes called an iron triangle: a small, stable set of participants, made up of a congressional committee, a government agency, and a handful of client interests, working together closely and largely out of public view to control policy in a given area. In this model, each actor depends on others for resources that it cannot obtain elsewhere (e.g., political support, budgetary appropriations, or favorable treatment). This arrangement was mutually reinforcing—insulating actors from outside scrutiny. Agricultural policy was often described this way, with the House and Senate agriculture committees, the U.S. Department of Agriculture, and major farm organizations such as the American Farm Bureau Federation portrayed as a closed alliance.

By the late 1970s, however, scholars began to argue that this tradition no longer accurately described how most policy areas actually operated. In a widely cited 1978 essay, political scientist Hugh Heclo argued that iron triangles were being usurped by loose, shifting issue networks. He described these networks as large, open sets of individuals connected by shared knowledge of and involvement with an issue. In contrast to the iron triangle, these individuals may not share a common ideology and need not have a cooperative relationship with one another. Heclo's issue network set the stage for later researchers to study these networks directly, using methods borrowed from sociology, and the concept of an interest system community draws these varied traditions together under a single frame.

## II Mapping and Structuring Interest Communities

Network and exchange had already emerged as organizing metaphors for community structure by the 1960s. During this time, however, efforts to study interest communities empirically relied largely on qualitative

*Department of Political Science, Washington University in St. Louis. Email: dinopc@wustl.edu.
†Department of Political Science, Washington University in St. Louis. Email: enathan@wustl.edu.

case studies. It was not until the 1980s that researchers began to treat policy areas as empirical networks of relationships that could be measured and mapped—much as a sociologist might map friendships within schools or business ties within industries.

This approach, social network analysis, asks who contacts whom and which organizations occupy central or peripheral positions. The first step in applying social network analysis to a policy area is to define who belongs. This is challenging, however, because policy areas have no natural or predefined list of members. Different reasonable boundary choices can yield very different pictures of the same community, a difficulty researchers term the boundary specification problem.

An early and influential application of network analysis to the study of interest groups mapped the energy and health care policy areas. Researchers found that each policy area contained an internally differentiated community, with some organizations occupying central, well-connected positions and many others tied to the network only loosely.

When mapped by their ties, most interest communities share a core-periphery structure. In the core, a small number of well-resourced organizations occupy central positions with frequent contact with government officials and one another. This typically includes large corporations, national labor unions, and peak associations—umbrella organizations that sit above a set of more specialized groups and claim to speak for an entire sector (e.g., the U.S. Chamber of Commerce or the AFL-CIO). From the core, these peak associations shape a community's overall structure. Research from the late 1980s shows that when peak associations are strong, rival peaks pull specialized groups into opposing camps, producing polarized conflict. On the other hand, when peak associations are divided or absent, communities instead fragment into narrower, shifting coalitions. In either case, a much larger number of narrowly focused groups occupy the outer edges of the community—participating occasionally and often through temporary coalitions. This has consequences for influence. Centrally located organizations are generally better positioned to shape a community's overall agenda. Peripheral organizations conversely tend to react to priorities set by the core or government.

A group's position in the interest community network is not fixed, however. Organizations form and dissolve ties over time, and their resources, membership, and even corporate structure shape which partners they attract. For instance, research tracking large companies through mergers and acquisitions finds that consolidation expands an organization's issue involvement and connections. These companies, however, do not necessarily become more powerful in the community—suggesting a ceiling effect for organizations that were already prominent.

The influence that central positions confer is similarly conditional. A study of coalition networks measures each organization's centrality among its coalition partners. The researchers find that centrality matters most to the outcome of a policy dispute when the competing sides are closely matched. Centrality matters far less when one side already holds an overwhelming numerical advantage.

Communities are also internally divided by specialization. Within a broad policy area, groups frequently sort into narrower issue niches. In these niches, a small set of organizations builds recognized expertise and avoids direct competition with groups working in adjacent niches. Associations representing corn or dairy producers, for example, typically focus on their own programs and rarely compete, even though both belong to the broader agricultural policy community.

This niche-based logic operates at the industry level as well. Comparative research on membership associations finds that business, professional, civic, and unclassified groups share closely related coalition structures. Religious, political, and labor associations, by contrast, are each structurally distinct. These differences reflect

each type's focus and reliance on grassroots mobilization.

## III How Communities Cohere

If interest communities are internally divided rather than uniformly close-knit, this raises an important question. What holds members together at all? The question arises first for individual groups. In his canonical 1965 book, The Logic of Collective Action, economist Mancur Olson argued that the benefits an organization secures are typically available to nonmembers as well as members. Thus, individuals have an incentive to free-ride—to enjoy those benefits without contributing to the group that won them. This problem is especially pressing for organizations that depend on voluntary membership. In 1969, political scientist Robert Salisbury proposed an answer by arguing that group formation is an exchange. Organizers invest in a set of benefits and offer them to prospective members in exchange for membership. Groups survive only while that exchange remains worthwhile to both sides—which helps explain why so many groups fail. At the level of whole communities, cohesion is weaker still. A later study of four major policy areas found that no single set of brokers mediated among competing interests within any of them. Instead, organizations clustered around narrow sub-issues and formed alliances that shifted as legislation moved through different stages—leading researchers to describe these communities as having a hollow core.

Coordination among community members tends to be issue-specific and temporary rather than fixed. One account of coalition behavior found that organizations often join lobbying coalitions strategically, sometimes belonging to several different, even competing, coalitions at once. A large-scale study of nearly one hundred policy debates similarly found that how coalitions lined up against one another predicted the outcome of a debate better than the size or budget of any single organization. The researchers argued that a typical debate divides into a coalition defending the status quo and one favoring change, with the status quo side holding a structural advantage in the American legislative process even when its opponents command greater resources. A study of endorsements in internal congressional communications known as Dear Colleague letters found a related pattern. An endorsement from one especially central organization mattered most early in the legislative process, when a bill competes with thousands of others for attention. However, after a bill had survived this initial winnowing, the sheer number of endorsing organizations had a much larger impact on legislative success. Beyond formal coalitions, communities are also linked through standing ties. These ties include shared staff, overlapping boards, and personal relationships—which persist even when no coalition or legislative issue is active and ensure that future cooperation is easier to arrange.

Political scientists Paul Sabatier and Hank Jenkins-Smith advanced a related—but distinct—explanation for interest community cohesion. They argue that coordination within a policy area is often organized around two or more competing coalitions of organized interests, officials, legislators, and researchers who share a common set of underlying beliefs about what policy should accomplish. This is a sharper form of coordination than the shared awareness that holds an issue network together. The authors posit that these coalitions can remain stable for a decade or more, revising their views on policy instruments in response to new information while holding to their core beliefs.

## IV Communities as Populations of Organizations

A different tradition treats interest communities not as networks of relationships but as populations of organizations. Key questions in this vein are how many groups a given issue or government attracts and why. Extant scholarship shows that organized interests distribute their attention very unevenly across the policy landscape. A handful of high-profile issues attract hundreds of organizations at once. Concurrently, most policy corners remain relatively quiet—drawing the interest of only a couple of groups.

Political scientists Virginia Gray and David Lowery applied ideas from the study of biological populations to organized interests. They use the term interest community to specifically describe the full population of organizations registered to lobby within a particular government (e.g., an American state government). Their work focuses on that population's density (the total number of active organizations) and its diversity (how that total is distributed across industries and issue areas). Across a series of works, Gray and Lowery found that competition for a state's limited attention and resources regulates how large a given category of organizations can grow, much as competition for food and space limits a biological population.

The population ecology scholarship differs from network research in an important way, treating a community as a count of organizations rather than a set of relationships between them. However, the two approaches complement one another. Population research helps explain why a community reaches a particular size and mix, while network research helps explain how members of that community coordinate and divide influence once formed.

## V Why These Communities Matter

Research on interest communities shifted scholarly attention away from the success of any single organization and toward its position within its broader community. Across several institutional settings (e.g., the U.S. Supreme Court, in Congress, and in the Senate's confirmation of executive branch nominees), the presence of a single well-connected organization has been shown to matter more than the sheer number of organizations weighing in. This structural view qualifies older explanations focused simply on an organization's financial resources or membership size. Indeed, a well-funded organization with few community connections can still struggle to shape an agenda that better-connected rivals control. Empirical studies repeatedly find only a weak relationship between how much an organization spends on lobbying and how often it prevails.

This line of research speaks to a much older debate about organized interests in American democracy. Political scientist Robert Dahl argued in his 1961 book, Who Governs?, that competition among many organized interests generally prevents any single narrow group from dominating policy outcomes—a view associated with pluralist theories of democracy. Political scientist E. E. Schattschneider took a different view in an equally influential 1960 book, The Semisovereign People, arguing that participation in interest group politics is heavily skewed toward business and the wealthy. Thus, competition among groups does not by itself guarantee a fair hearing for all interests. Research on interest communities lends some support to Schattschneider's concern. Most organizations occupy peripheral positions, while access and agenda-setting power is concentrated among a smaller, better connected core. Nevertheless, the sheer number of organizations active in most communities reflects the broad participation pluralist theories emphasize.

Interest communities are held together by many shifting, issue-specific coalitions layered on a smaller, more stable core. As such, changes in how those coalitions line up can produce shifts in public policy that neither

a theory of stable, closed subgovernments nor a theory focused on single organizations would predict. The health care debate that led to passage of the Affordable Care Act in 2010, for example, involved a changing lineup of insurers, hospital associations, physician groups, and patient advocacy organizations. Thus, coalition realignment can accompany major legislative change, connecting the study of interest communities to broader theories of policy change.

## VI Ongoing Research and Open Questions

Though this entry focuses on the American context, researchers have mapped interest communities in many other settings. This includes much of Western Europe, Canada, and Australia—as well as transnational arenas such as the European Union (EU). This comparative literature is burgeoning, but it leaves several open questions. For one, moving beyond the United States sharpens the boundary specification problem described earlier. In the EU, for instance, lobbying registration has long been voluntary, so different lists of organizations produce different pictures of the same community, and researchers have responded by merging multiple sources into a single population data set. Even so, researchers have shown that a map built from organizations lobbying on specific EU proposals contains far more business organizations and far fewer citizen groups than one built from the EU's general register. How to define an interest community's boundaries thus remains one of the field's central open questions, particularly as research extends beyond the United States. A second gap concerns network structure. Most comparative work counts organizations rather than mapping the ties among them. Only recently have scholars mapped EU interest communities as networks across policy domains, in one piece, for example, using follower ties on Twitter. Similarly, network studies of Latin American legislatures are just beginning. Finally, networks of organized interests in courts outside the United States have received little attention.

Several additional methodological challenges remain unresolved. One strand involves sampling and measurement procedures. Studies that rely on sampling from lists of readily identifiable organizations may risk understating the involvement of less visible, less well-resourced participants. Likewise, the hollow core finding, that even a community's most central organizations coordinate only loosely, rests on interview-based methods. It is thus unclear whether the hollow core is a lasting feature of communities or an artifact of the methods used in the studies that first identified it.

A related challenge is comparing communities that differ structurally. Statistical models have been developed that allow researchers to measure how closely communities share the same structural tendencies. Subsequent work has combined network models with scaling techniques to place multiple interest communities on a shared map for comparison. Newer community detection methods go further, identifying a community's internal divisions directly from the network data itself. Applications are revealing. One recent study examined organizations filing amicus curiae briefs in immigration cases before the U.S. Supreme Court. community detection showed It found that some organizations work only within a single, tightly knit set of partners while others bridge several distinct clusters. Bridging organizations proved more persuasive to justices, but only on one side of the ideological divide—thus underscoring how conditional a community's influence on outcomes can be.

*Dino P. Christenson*
*Nathan Englehart*

**See also:** Advocacy Coalition Framework; Collective Action Problem; Iron Triangle; Issue Networks; Lobbying Coalitions; Peak Associations; Policy Domains; Population Ecology of Interest Groups

## VII Further Readings


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